subcontinent seems to have lived without a successor writing system for over a millennium, until the rise of the Brahmi script that we know from Ashoka's edicts. By then, the script must have been in use for a while, and evidence of its earliest use has turned up in Anuradhapura, Sri Lanka, in 6–5 centuries BCE.[36] It's currently safe to say that the flame of a literate urban civilization wasn't lit again for over a millennium.

One theory for the demise of Harappan cities blames regional climate change that likely caused a sustained drop in monsoon rains, making the entire region more arid and impairing the ability of the agricultural hinterland to feed its cities.[37] Support for this theory comes from the common depiction of animals like rhino, buffalo, elephant and tiger, which thrive in wetter climes. Another theory blames earthquakes, which likely altered the path of Indus River, impacting Harappa and Mohenjo-Daro, and turned the Ghaggar-Hakra River from a perennial Himalayan-sourced river into a monsoonal one, impacting Ganweriwala and Rakhigarhi. More frequent flooding, as in Mohenjo-Daro, may have caused more outbreaks of malaria or cholera, making people leave, but the evidence for this is still weak. It's also possible that new beliefs and material conditions led to a breakdown of earlier social relations between the city and the village, making it harder for the city to raise taxes from its rural hinterland. In other words, the cause of their demise is very much an unsettled debate, and likely involved multiple factors.

Whatever the cause, the Harappans and their descendants began moving east and south—a process already underway for millennia but had now gathered momentum—some to the Ganga–Yamuna plains, many more to the southern parts of the subcontinent. DNA analysis shows close genetic proximity between the Harappans and modern south Indians.[38] Even the Harappan language was very likely proto-Dravidian. Support for this comes from the proximity between modern Dravidian languages and Elamite, a deciphered but extinct language of Iran with a logo-syllabic script. Speakers of proto-Elamite, which however remains undeciphered, were neighbours to the Harappans and traded with them. Another strong clue is an isolated pocket of a Dravidian language, Brahui, a close relative of Elamite that still survives in Baluchistan, where the Harappans lived. Brahui today has 300,000 speakers; their ancestors very likely did not migrate there from